

Mouselike rodents

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Rodentia
SUBORDER	Myomorpha
FAMILIES	7
SPECIES	1,737

This suborder—which is distinguished from the other 4 rodent suborders by the way the jaw muscles are arranged (see p.116)—constitutes over a quarter of all mammal species. Within the group are rats and mice (including voles, lemmings, hamsters, and gerbils), and jerboas. Mouselike rodents often have a pointed face and long whiskers,

and are usually small, nocturnal seed-eaters. They are found worldwide (except Antarctica), in almost all terrestrial habitats. Some species, such as the naked mole-rat, live underground; others, such as the water vole, occupy aquatic habitats. Species that live in open areas may have longer legs and feet (for quick escapes), and larger ears to detect danger from a distance.



PROLIFIC BREEDERS
Mouselike rodents, such as this harvest mouse, usually have large litters.

Oxymycterus nasutus

Long-nosed hociudo



Length 3¼–6½ in (9.5–17 cm)
Tail 2¾–5¼ in (7–14.5 cm)
Weight 3¼ oz (90 g)

Location E. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This large mouse rarely comes out into the open. It forages by day under leaves, logs, and stones for creatures such as grubs and worms, sniffing with its long, flexible, shrewlike snout and scrabbling up prey with its large-clawed forefeet. Its back is black, tinged with red or yellow, and is darker along the midline; its flanks are yellow-brown; the underside is yellow-orange mixed with gray; and the short, scaly tail is sparsely haired. It rarely excavates its own tunnels or pathways, using those of other rodents.

Baiomys taylori

Northern pygmy mouse



Length 2–2½ in (5–6.5 cm)
Tail 1½–1¾ in (3.5–4.5 cm)
Weight ¼–½ oz (7–9 g)

Location S. USA to C. Mexico
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The female of this species, North America's smallest rodent, can become pregnant at the youngest age of any New World mouse—just 4 weeks. The fur is mid-brown on the back and gray underneath. This mouse occupies a territory up to 100 ft (30 m) across and feeds at twilight on plants and seeds. Its nest is in a burrow under logs or plants.

Rhizomys sinensis

Chinese bamboo rat



Length 9–16 in (22–40 cm)
Tail 2–3¾ in (5–9.5 cm)
Weight 2¼–6½ lb (1–3 kg)

Location E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This beaverlike rat has thick gray-brown fur, a squat snout, and short, scaly tail. It lives in bamboo thickets, digging tunnels and nest chambers between the roots. An excellent climber, it feeds on bamboo as well as seeds and fruit.

Tachyoryctes macrocephalus

Ethiopian African mole rat



Length 12 in (31 cm)
Tail 3½–4 in (9–10 cm)
Weight 13–36 oz (350–1,000 g)

Location E. Africa
Social unit Variable
Status Endangered



This giant African mole rat lives like a mole, spending a great deal of time in its burrow. This may exceed 165 ft (50 m) in length and houses one rat. Burrowing adaptations include a



blunt and rounded head, robust body, short limbs, small eyes and ears, and thick fur. This mole rat gnaws roots and other plant parts with its large, projecting, orange-yellow incisors, and digs its extensive tunnel system in the same way.

Reithrodontomys raviventris

Saltmarsh harvest mouse



Length 2¼–3 in (7–7.5 cm)
Tail 1¼–4½ in (4.5–11.5 cm)
Weight ¼–¾ oz (6–20 g)

Location W. USA (San Francisco Bay area)
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



Similar to the house mouse (see p.128), the saltmarsh harvest mouse has large ears and a long tail. It builds a summer nest of grass above ground in a bush or undergrowth, and feeds on seeds, shoots, and insects. In winter, it moves into a burrow that has been dug, but then deserted, by another rodent.



Peromyscus leucopus

White-footed mouse



Length 3½–4¼ in (9–10.5 cm)
Tail 2½–4 in (6–10 cm)
Weight ½–1½ oz (14–30 g)

Location S.E. Canada to Mexico
Social unit Paired
Status Least concern



A widespread and common species, this mouse resembles others in the deer mouse group, with its white feet and underparts, and brown fur on the back. White-footed mice usually live in pairs, which occupy a small

den in a sheltered place under tree roots, below a log or stone, or in a thicket; or they may dig a den in soil, or take over an abandoned burrow. The nest is made from soft, dry plant matter, including shredded stems. The pair forage principally at night for fruit, berries, seeds, and insects, staying mainly on the ground even though they climb well. Food is stored in the den near the nest, covered with soil. In cold weather, the white-footed mouse may hibernate for a few hours each day. The female is pregnant for 22–23 days, and the average litter size is 4–5.



white underfur and feet